January 2026 Current Affairs — Top 30 MCQs

High-Yield Practice Set with Answers & Detailed Explanations for RRB NTPC & Sub-Inspector (SI) Exams

Question Difficulty & Pattern Tags: STRAIGHTFORWARD Direct fact-based (CBT 1 Focus) TRICKY Subtle factual traps & negative phrasing IN-DEPTH Multi-statement & analytical (CBT 2 / SI Focus)

1. Republic Day, Economy & Padma Awards 2026

STRAIGHTFORWARD **Q1.**

Which European nation officially adopted the Euro as its official currency on January 1, 2026, becoming the 21st member of the Eurozone?

A) Romania

B) Bulgaria

C) Hungary

D) Poland

Answer: B) Bulgaria

Explanation: On January 1, 2026, Bulgaria replaced its national currency, the Bulgarian Lev (BGN), with the Euro, officially becoming the 21st member state of the Eurozone.

TRICKY **Q2.**

Which of the following statements regarding the 77th Republic Day Parade (2026) is INCORRECT?

A) The central theme celebrated 150 years of 'Vande Mataram'.

B) A total of 30 tableaux participated in the parade.

C) The Indian Navy showcased a Battle Array Formation for the first time.

D) Rare 1923 paintings by Tejendra Kumar Mitra were displayed along the route.

Answer: C) The Indian Navy showcased a Battle Array Formation for the first time.

Explanation: The Indian Army (not the Navy) showcased a Battle Array Formation for the first time during the 2026 parade, accompanied by a fly-past of 29 Armed Forces aircraft.

IN-DEPTH **Q3.**

Consider the following statements about the 77th Republic Day tableaux (2026):
1. Out of 30 tableaux, 17 belonged to States/UTs and 13 belonged to Central Ministries/Departments.
2. The tableaux were organized under the twin themes *"Swatantrata ka Mantra – Vande Mataram"* and *"Samriddhi ka Mantra – Atmanirbhar Bharat"*.
3. Both themes were exclusively dedicated to India's space and defense achievements.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A) 1 only
B) 1 and 2 only
C) 2 and 3 only
D) 1, 2, and 3

Answer: B) 1 and 2 only
Explanation: Statements 1 and 2 are accurate. Statement 3 is incorrect because the themes broadly celebrated cultural heritage (Vande Mataram) and self-reliance (Atmanirbhar Bharat), not just space and defense.

STRAIGHTFORWARD **Q4.**

How many total Padma Awards were approved by President Droupadi Murmu on the eve of Republic Day 2026 (counting duo cases as one)?

A) 128
B) 131
C) 135
D) 139

Answer: B) 131
Explanation: The 2026 Padma Awards list comprised 131 awards in total: 5 Padma Vibhushan, 13 Padma Bhushan, and 113 Padma Shri awards.

TRICKY **Q5.**

Which of the following personalities was NOT conferred the Padma Vibhushan in January 2026?

A) Dharmendra Singh Deol (Posthumous)
B) V. S. Achuthanandhan (Posthumous)
C) N. Rajam
D) Mammootty

Answer: D) Mammootty
Explanation: Veteran actor Mammootty received the Padma Bhushan (not Padma Vibhushan) in 2026. The five Padma Vibhushan recipients were Dharmendra Singh Deol, Justice (Retd.) K. T. Thomas, N. Rajam, P. Narayanan, and V. S. Achuthanandhan.

IN-DEPTH **Q6.**

Match the following Padma Bhushan 2026 recipients with their respective fields:
1. Vijay Amritraj — (a) Trade & Industry
2. Uday Kotak — (b) Sports
3. Alka Yagnik — (c) Public Affairs
4. Shibu Soren — (d) Art

A) 1-b, 2-a, 3-d, 4-c
B) 1-a, 2-b, 3-c, 4-d
C) 1-b, 2-d, 3-a, 4-c
D) 1-c, 2-a, 3-d, 4-b

Answer: A) 1-b, 2-a, 3-d, 4-c
Explanation: Tennis legend Vijay Amritraj was honored in Sports, banker Uday Kotak in Trade & Industry, playback singer Alka Yagnik in Art, and former Jharkhand CM Shibu Soren (Posthumous) in Public Affairs.

TRICKY **Q7.**

In the Padma Awards 2026 list, what was the exact count of women recipients and posthumous awardees respectively?

A) 16 women and 19 posthumous
B) 19 women and 16 posthumous
C) 21 women and 14 posthumous
D) 19 women and 19 posthumous

Answer: B) 19 women and 16 posthumous
Explanation: Examiners frequently swap paired statistics. The 2026 list included 19 women, 16 posthumous awardees, and 6 persons from the Foreigners/NRI/PIO/OCI category.

STRAIGHTFORWARD **Q8.**

Which pair of Indian cricket captains was conferred the Padma Shri in January 2026?

A) Virat Kohli and Smriti Mandhana
B) Rohit Sharma and Harmanpreet Kaur
C) Jasprit Bumrah and Mithali Raj
D) Suryakumar Yadav and Deepti Sharma

Answer: B) Rohit Sharma and Harmanpreet Kaur
Explanation: Both Indian men's captain Rohit Sharma and women's captain Harmanpreet Kaur were honored with the Padma Shri in the 2026 list.

STRAIGHTFORWARD **Q9.**

Which Indian women's hockey goalkeeper received the Padma Shri in January 2026?

A) Rani Rampal
B) Savita Punia
C) Vandana Katariya
D) Salima Tete

Answer: B) Savita Punia
Explanation: Veteran Indian goalkeeper Savita Punia was conferred the Padma Shri in January 2026 for her contributions to field hockey.

2. Indian Railways, Polity & National News

STRAIGHTFORWARD **Q10.**

Who was honored with Indian Railways' highest service award, the 'Ati Vishisht Rail Seva Puraskar', in January 2026?

A) Jaya Varma Sinha
B) Satish Kumar
C) Chandana Sinha
D) Anil Kumar Lahoti

Answer: C) Chandana Sinha
Explanation: Chandana Sinha received the prestigious Ati Vishisht Rail Seva Puraskar in January 2026, making this a top-priority question for RRB NTPC.

IN-DEPTH **Q11.**

Which edition of the India–EU Summit was co-chaired in New Delhi in January 2026, resulting in the conclusion of long-pending Free Trade Agreement (FTA) negotiations?

A) 14th India–EU Summit
B) 15th India–EU Summit
C) 16th India–EU Summit
D) 18th India–EU Summit

Answer: C) 16th India–EU Summit
Explanation: Held alongside the 77th Republic Day visit of EU leaders, the 16th India–EU Summit concluded marathon FTA negotiations and advanced cooperation under Horizon Europe.

STRAIGHTFORWARD **Q12.**

Which Indian state officially declared the 'Malabar Tree Toad' as its first state amphibian in January 2026?

A) Kerala
B) Karnataka
C) Tamil Nadu
D) Goa

Answer: B) Karnataka
Explanation: Karnataka declared the Malabar Tree Toad (Pedostibes tuberculosus), an endemic Western Ghats species, as its first official state amphibian.

IN-DEPTH **Q13.**

Which three ancient Indian texts were inscribed in the UNESCO Asia-Pacific Memory of the World Register in January 2026?

A) Rigveda, Upanishads, and Panchatantra
B) Mahabharata, Rajatarangini, and Arthashastra
C) Ramayana, Natyashastra, and Charaka Samhita
D) Manusmriti, Bhagavad Gita, and Harshacharita

Answer: B) Mahabharata, Rajatarangini, and Arthashastra
Explanation: UNESCO added the Mahabharata (epic), Kalhana's Rajatarangini (history of Kashmir), and Kautilya's Arthashastra (statecraft) to its Asia-Pacific Memory of the World Register in January 2026.

TRICKY **Q14.**

Which country joined the International Solar Alliance (ISA) as its 116th member in January 2026?

A) Barbados
B) The Bahamas
C) Fiji
D) Jamaica

Answer: B) The Bahamas

Explanation: The Bahamas became the 116th member country to ratify the ISA Framework Agreement. (Static Link: ISA is headquartered in Gurugram, Haryana).

TRICKY **Q15.**

Which state celebrated its 54th Statehood Day on January 21, 2026, alongside Manipur and Tripura?

A) Mizoram
B) Arunachal Pradesh
C) Meghalaya
D) Nagaland

Answer: C) Meghalaya

Explanation: Manipur, Meghalaya, and Tripura attained full statehood on January 21, 1972, under the North-Eastern Areas (Reorganisation) Act, 1971—marking their 54th Statehood Day in January 2026. (Mizoram and Arunachal Pradesh became states later in 1987).

3. Appointments, Defense & International Honours

STRAIGHTFORWARD **Q16.**

Who took charge as the new Director General of the Geological Survey of India (GSI) in January 2026?

A) Asit Saha
B) Dinesh Vitthal Rao Ganvir
C) Janardan Prasad
D) Rajendra Singh Gharatiya

Answer: B) Dinesh Vitthal Rao Ganvir

Explanation: Dinesh Vitthal Rao Ganvir assumed office as Director General of GSI in January 2026.

TRICKY **Q17.**

Where is the headquarters of the Geological Survey of India (GSI), whose new DG was appointed in January 2026, located?

A) New Delhi
B) Nagpur
C) Kolkata
D) Dehradun

Answer: C) Kolkata

Explanation: RRB NTPC frequently asks static headquarters linked to recent appointments. GSI was founded in 1851 and is headquartered in Kolkata, West Bengal.

STRAIGHTFORWARD **Q18.**

Who was appointed as the Director General of Police (DGP) of Arunachal Pradesh in January 2026?

A) Anand Mohan
B) Rajesh Kumar
C) Sagar Preet Hooda
D) Nalin Prabhat

Answer: B) Rajesh Kumar
Explanation: Senior IPS officer Rajesh Kumar was appointed DGP of Arunachal Pradesh in January 2026.

STRAIGHTFORWARD **Q19.**

Who took over as the Director General of Integrated Training in January 2026?

A) Lt. Gen. Sushil Chander Mahant
B) Lt. Gen. Upendra Dwivedi
C) Lt. Gen. Rakesh Kapoor
D) Lt. Gen. Dhiraj Seth

Answer: A) Lt. Gen. Sushil Chander Mahant
Explanation: Lt. Gen. Sushil Chander Mahant was appointed Director General of Integrated Training in January 2026.

STRAIGHTFORWARD **Q20.**

Which renowned Indian cardiac surgeon was conferred the 'Knight of the French National Order of Merit' in January 2026?

A) Dr. Naresh Trehan
B) Dr. Devi Shetty
C) Dr. Ramakanta Panda
D) Dr. K. M. Cherian

Answer: B) Dr. Devi Shetty
Explanation: Dr. Devi Shetty, founder of Narayana Health, received France's prestigious Knight of the National Order of Merit in January 2026 for his contributions to affordable healthcare.

4. Sports (January 2026)

STRAIGHTFORWARD **Q21.**

Which team won the 2025–26 Vijay Hazare Trophy final held on January 18, 2026?

A) Karnataka
B) Vidarbha
C) Saurashtra
D) Tamil Nadu

Answer: B) Vidarbha
Explanation: Vidarbha clinched the 2025–26 Vijay Hazare Trophy (India's premier domestic 50-over cricket tournament) on January 18, 2026.

STRAIGHTFORWARD **Q22.**

Who became India's 100th Chess Grandmaster in January 2026?

A) Pranav Venkatesh

B) Anuj Shrivatri

C) Aditya Samant

D) Leon Luke Mendonca

Answer: B) Anuj Shrivatri

Explanation: Anuj Shrivatri achieved the milestone of becoming India's 100th Chess Grandmaster in January 2026.

TRICKY **Q23.**

Regarding New Zealand's white-ball tour of India (January 11–31, 2026), which of the following results is correct?

A) India won both the ODI and T20I series.

B) New Zealand won both the ODI and T20I series.

C) New Zealand won the ODI series, while India won the T20I series.

D) India won the ODI series, while New Zealand won the T20I series.

Answer: C) New Zealand won the ODI series, while India won the T20I series.

Explanation: Many candidates assume India swept both home series, making this a classic trap. New Zealand won the ODI leg, whereas India bounced back to win the T20I series.

IN-DEPTH **Q24.**

Which three Indian cities hosted matches of the Men's Hockey India League in January 2026?

A) New Delhi, Lucknow, and Mumbai

B) Chennai, Ranchi, and Bhubaneswar

C) Rourkela, Bengaluru, and Chandigarh

D) Hyderabad, Pune, and Kolkata

Answer: B) Chennai, Ranchi, and Bhubaneswar

Explanation: The Men's Hockey India League in January 2026 was hosted across three venues: Chennai, Ranchi, and Bhubaneswar.

STRAIGHTFORWARD **Q25.**

Which Indian city hosted the Tata Steel India Rapid & Blitz Chess Tournament in January 2026?

A) Chennai

B) Mumbai

C) Kolkata

D) New Delhi

Answer: C) Kolkata

Explanation: Kolkata hosted the 2026 edition of the Tata Steel Chess India Rapid & Blitz tournament in January.

IN-DEPTH **Q26.**

Which of the following sportspersons received the Padma Shri in January 2026 in the Para-Athletics category?

A) Sumit Antil

B) Praveen Kumar

C) Avani Lekhara

D) Mariyappan Thangavelu

Answer: B) Praveen Kumar

Explanation: High jumper Praveen Kumar was honored with the Padma Shri in January 2026 under the Para-Athletics category, alongside martial artists Bhagwandas Raikwar and K. Pajanivel.

5. Important Days & History Links (SI & NTPC Special)

STRAIGHTFORWARD **Q27.**

'Parakram Diwas' is observed every year on January 23 to mark the birth anniversary of which freedom fighter?

A) Lala Lajpat Rai

B) Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose

C) Bhagat Singh

D) Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel

Answer: B) Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose

Explanation: January 23 is celebrated nationwide as Parakram Diwas (Day of Valour) to honor Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose.

IN-DEPTH **Q28.**

Indian Army Day is celebrated on January 15 every year. What historical event occurred on this exact date in 1949?

A) The Indian Army liberated Goa from Portuguese rule.

B) Field Marshal K. M. Cariappa took over as the first Indian Commander-in-Chief from General Sir Francis Bucher.

C) The National Defence Academy (NDA) was inaugurated at Khadakwasla.

D) The Gallantry Awards (Param Vir Chakra) were instituted.

Answer: B) Field Marshal K. M. Cariappa took over as the first Indian Commander-in-Chief from General Sir Francis Bucher.

Explanation: SI exams often test the historical reason behind important days. On January 15, 1949, K. M. Cariappa became the first Indian Commander-in-Chief of the Indian Army, replacing the last British commander, General Sir Francis Bucher.

TRICKY **Q29.**

National Voters' Day (January 25) marks the foundation day of the Election Commission of India (1950). In which year was National Voters' Day observed for the VERY FIRST time?

A) 1950

B) 2001

C) 2011

D) 2014

Answer: C) 2011

Explanation: While the ECI was founded on January 25, 1950, the Government of India started celebrating National Voters' Day in 2011 to mark the ECI's 61st foundation year and encourage youth voter registration.

TRICKY **Q30.**

Which of the following January Important Days is INCORRECTLY matched?

A) January 9 — Pravasi Bharatiya Divas

B) January 12 — National Youth Day

C) January 16 — National Startup Day

D) January 24 — National Science Day

Answer: D) January 24 — National Science Day

Explanation: January 24 is observed as National Girl Child Day (and International Day of Education). National Science Day is observed on February 28 to commemorate C. V. Raman's discovery of the Raman Effect.